

Plot/Intro [00:00:02–00:00:22]

Welcome to The Lighter Side of the Spectrum, a podcast where we explore how to find joy, connection, and growth while navigating the challenges of parenting kids and teens on the autism spectrum. Remember that inclusion and hope are key to making life better for everyone, and that even in the most challenging moments, there's always a lighter side. Now here's your host, David Kaufer.

David Kaufer [00:00:22–00:01:02]

I'm David, and I'm the father of 18-year-old twin boys, one of whom was diagnosed on the autism spectrum. Just before he turned 3. So I've been on this journey for a long time and have had a chance to work with a lot of different people, have met a lot of different people. I've learned a lot of things over the time. And so the goal of this podcast is really to try to share some of the knowledge, a lot of the expertise that I've gathered in the form of people, great people like my guest today, Elizabeth Zielinski. Elizabeth, thanks for joining me on one of our first Thank you for having me.

Denise Allen [00:01:02–00:01:24]

I resonate with what you said about learning so much from the people along the way. There's a, um, an Elton John song I love, um, and there's a line in it that says, thank the Lord for the people I have known. And it's so true about this process that I don't know how people get through it without a community.

David Kaufer [00:01:26–00:03:14]

And that's funny that you mentioned that because that's one of the topics I want to talk about today, actually, is community and the role that it plays, especially some of the opportunities, but also it kind of creates some challenges. So just to give, you know, listeners and viewers just a little bit of background, Elizabeth was kind enough to send over her bio, but I want to give a little bit of background because she's really— she's just being a great person, just really impressive.

So Elizabeth is the founder and lead advocate of Virginia-based Commonwealth Education Group, LLC, a special education consulting practice designed to bring people, uh, bring together, I'm sorry, collaborative teams in a variety of educational specialty areas towards the common goal of assisting families with their students' educational planning. Experts in the group include advocates, attorneys, counselors, psychologists, educators, depending on the unique needs of the client.

So that's a mouthful, but what, you know, caught my eye initially is that, um, Elizabeth and I met in a Facebook group, um, for spellers. And so, uh, for those who don't know, um, spelling is a methodology that's used by nonspeakers, um, generally pointing at, uh, utilizing either a letterboard or keyboard typing. It's in our case, again, was the key to unlocking communication with our son who wasn't able to communicate for 16 years. Elizabeth, I want to hear about your experience as well.

But we met in this Facebook group and Elizabeth talked about how she's an advocate, advocate for families and has given a lot of great free advice. But I know that this is also your business. So, you know, why don't we just kind of start with that, your journey, Elizabeth, in terms of what brought you here? I know that there's a lot probably to talk about.

Denise Allen [00:03:16–00:03:25]

But yeah, yeah. Well, Evan was— Evan's my autistic son. He's almost 19 at the time we're recording this podcast. He'll be 19 in 2 weeks.

David Kaufer [00:03:25–00:03:26]

Right.

Denise Allen [00:03:26–00:03:59]

Um, and he was diagnosed autistic when he was 3, but he was diagnosed non-speaking or, or unreliably speaking. Gosh, he was barely over 2. I mean, of course, back then you didn't get the super, super early diagnoses that a lot of families get today, which is great that families do get that. Um, but, uh, he didn't have communication until he was about 11. We had— there's a few different modalities available in the community. They're all letterboard-based communication. We've done them all. Um, we almost did—

David Kaufer [00:03:59–00:04:00]

Globe, right?

Denise Allen [00:04:00–00:04:35]

Yeah, right. Um, and I don't want to, you know, be too, too derivative, but it really was finding the right community that made one work over another because you need that collective support as you're going through this process. And so, you know, we had a couple of false starts with different modalities, and then I had to be convinced that it would even work. Not because I, I'm, I might be something of an exception in that I always, always, always believed that Evan had more in there. What I didn't believe is whether we'd ever reach it. And, you know, 100%.

David Kaufer [00:04:36–00:04:36]

Yeah.

Denise Allen [00:04:36–00:04:37]

Yeah. I always knew it.

David Kaufer [00:04:37–00:04:38]

Yep.

Denise Allen [00:04:39–00:06:12]

Now he, you know, he's not, he doesn't meet the stereotypical aspects of autism. He's very, um, very affectionate. He makes good eye contact. He, you know, really super oriented to social cues. He doesn't necessarily respond to social cues, but he absolutely understands them.

Um, so I just didn't, I, I thought that what he could say is what he could say, and I didn't know that there was any other any other way to pursue that, we put so much priority on the spoken word that we took it at face value, that what he said was what he meant to say, and that what he didn't say was, you know, maybe he didn't understand or he didn't, I, I don't know what. But I always knew there was more there and I just didn't know if we'd reach it. So it took a couple of people kicking me in the backside saying, just give it a try, give it a try.

And right from the beginning, I mean, we all have our, what I call 'em, our magical moments, you know, where there's just one thing that they do or, or, or spell. I tend to use the word say as interchangeable with spelling because it is what he's saying. Just wanna make that clear for anybody listening because it doesn't mean he's speaking it. Um, but he's still saying it.

So in any case, um, you know, very early on we had that magical moment that, and in his case, it was one that I not only was absolutely certain was genuinely him, meaning the person holding the letterboard could not possibly have known.

Plot/Intro [00:06:12–00:06:13]

Right.

Denise Allen [00:06:13–00:06:37]

Um, but the, the thing that he spoke about or wrote about, um, was just very specifically unique to his personality. And it just, you know, I, it just, it was one of those things that you just, I don't, I, I think maybe it was the only time in my life that I just dropped on my knees and it was just so— yeah, literally, literally. I mean, I'd love to tell the story if we have time for that.

Plot/Intro [00:06:37–00:06:38]

Please.

David Kaufer [00:06:38–00:07:23]

No, please do. Yeah, no, I would. I think because I think, I think it's important, like you said, because again, um, as you said, you didn't go into this, you know, like starry-eyed, like, you know, like, hey, this is going to be it. I mean, again, I was, I, you know, I, I became aware of it from a friend who, who happened to be friends with JB Hanley. And, you know, I mean, and, you know, we as parents, right, we— I'm sure you went through everything you could think of.

I, again, I don't know, we've never really talked about, you know, some of the biomedical things, but as well as, you know, our ABA speech, right? There's anything and everything, right? We, we've been there. And, and yeah, nothing had seemed to quote unquote work because, again, like you said, we're so

focused on the spoken word.

Denise Allen [00:07:23–00:07:48]

So, and yes, and I will say too, I, you know, we didn't pursue biomed quite as much, um, in our— I don't want to get on a tangent, but in— I, we never had that profound moment where we saw loss of skills. We never saw them develop. And I, I hate to say this, but I— well, I don't hate to say this. I take that back. Um, I put a lot, a lot of stock in maternal instinct and—

David Kaufer [00:07:48–00:07:49]

Sure.

Denise Allen [00:07:49–00:08:25]

Possibly paternal too, but never having been a father to my knowledge, I don't, can't speak to that. Um, I just feel like every time I've known something in my heart and soul about my children, it's just never been wrong. And, and, you know, thousands of years of evolution created us to know these things on a level that we don't necessarily logically think through. And I just, I, I know what I, what I really expect. I think he, it, in his case, it very much was a genetic, you know, he was just created this way. But I also believe he experienced an environmental trigger.

Plot/Intro [00:08:25–00:08:26]

Mm-hmm.

Denise Allen [00:08:26–00:08:54]

That his own genome was less able to be responsive to. And I'm choosing my words very carefully because he is absolutely perfect exactly the way he is. I never speak about him in terms of, you know, any kind of medical damage or, um, anything that way. I think that that's, for me personally, I can't speak for others. For me personally, I think it's a fool's errand to go down that path because he is who he is.

Plot/Intro [00:08:54–00:08:55]

Mm-hmm.

Denise Allen [00:08:55–00:09:34]

And he deserves, he deserves to be loved and honored and embraced for exactly who he is. How he became that way is really not my question to answer. Um, I think I know, but You know, I mean, I was born with red hair. A lot of people thousands of years ago thought that was a sign of a witch. Right. And they weren't necessarily wrong. But my point is, you know, this is just, it's who he is. It's who he is and that's all. So anyway, back to the story of, of that moment. Um, again, not to get off on a tangent, but my, my parents, um, passed away 7 weeks apart from one another in— Oh, I'm sorry. Yeah, same period. So I don't recommend it.

David Kaufer [00:09:35–00:09:35]

No, that's rough.

Denise Allen [00:09:35–00:10:31]

It was rough. I don't recommend it. And one of the great sadnesses for me, my mother was a special education teacher and my dad was just, you know, a, a, um, just loved children, loved them. Just a natural, natural parent. And, um, they passed away in 2011.

We found spelling late 2015. It was early 2016. And as we were Coming to know this, this reality for Evan, one of my great sadnesses was, oh my gosh, mom and dad would've loved this. And if they're watching from the great beyond, man, they are just bursting. Oh yeah.

And, um, they're jacked. Um, yeah. Yeah. So we were in Austin, Texas. We had gone to see Selma Mukhopadhyay, the founder of RPM, and we were in a week-long, um, intensive program that she does.

And he had a half-hour session on the second day and he had what I call a DEF CON 1.

Plot/Intro [00:10:32–00:10:32]

Meltdown.

David Kaufer [00:10:32–00:10:33]

Interesting.

Denise Allen [00:10:33–00:12:25]

Um, I mean, just— I don't want to get into specifics out of dignity for him, but man, it was ugly. I think we even scared Selma. And he went out to the driveway of the home where her office is and got into our rental car and sat there and was just kicking and screaming and banging. And, um, she just kept going. She just kept the board in front of him.

And I, I, I was recording because Everything gets video recorded. And, um, the last thing he, she asked him was, what's one word to describe our time together? And he spelled hope. And what nobody knew at that time was that word hope was incredibly profound in my family of origin. My father worked with cancer patients and, um, he did a lot of the communication strategy, a lot of the public relations, and in the '70s.

The, the idea of hope being something that you can always bring to that lived experience. Um, I, I don't, I don't need to go into a lot of detail about that. The point is it's just a very, very specific word that had deep meaning for my family. And, um, for him to choose that one, and I am absolutely certain he chose that one specifically because he wanted me to hear him. He wanted me to know exactly what I was seeing.

Because Selma was just like, oh yeah, that's a nice word. She didn't, she didn't have no reason to know that that meant what it did. And I just, I felt the presence of my parents and I, I knew exactly what I was, what I was watching. And there was no, there was no turning back. I mean, RPM was not the model that worked well for us in the end, but, um, that was the moment and I will never regret that. trial and error we found because it gave me that gift.

David Kaufer [00:12:25–00:12:29]

Yeah, it got, he got you going, right? I sent you on the journey.

Plot/Intro [00:12:29–00:12:31]

Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:12:31–00:12:31]

Yeah.

Denise Allen [00:12:32–00:12:36]

And now, now I have Evan's word right here. That's my father's handwriting.

David Kaufer [00:12:36–00:12:37]

Oh, that's awesome.

Denise Allen [00:12:38–00:12:46]

My father's handwriting that I took from a document after he passed. And, and for me, it's both of them. It's, it's his word, but Evan's use of it.

David Kaufer [00:12:46–00:13:50]

That, that is super cool. I really like that. And, and I'm sorry, like you said, you know, your parents weren't able to witness that because it is, it is profound. And I'm fortunate enough that both of my parents are still alive. I have a 91-year-old dad and 89-year-old mom, you know, who were able to witness this with Stone.

They both— they've been divorced for years. But again, you know, I've had good relationships and have always been super supportive, especially Grandma. And just to talk about that moment. We were visiting not too long ago. They lived down in a couple hours away down the Portland area.

And Stone said, "I I wanted to say something to Grandma." I said, "Yeah, what do you want to say?"

He said, "Grandma, your unconditional love for me." Oh, and he said, "The reason the reason I always kept going was because of the unconditional love you gave me." And it was just like so. Sweet and special, right? You know, and just, you know, just totally melted her. You know, it's just it was a really sweet moment.

Denise Allen [00:13:51–00:13:58]

Well, nobody loves your kids the way that their grandparents do, right? Like after you, the only people

are are your parents.

David Kaufer [00:13:59–00:15:18]

Yeah, yeah. So I'm I'm you know like I said we're we're fortunate that we've had that and that he's had that relationship and that unconditional love and and you know the community like getting back. Getting back to that, like you said, it's so important because the journey, like again, when we started back when our sons were diagnosed even, it was pretty lonely. You didn't have a chance to necessarily meet other parents of children on the spectrum. It was far and few between.

There weren't necessarily Facebook groups or I remember there was a Yahoo group or things like that. So when you had a chance to connect with someone, it was really kind of a unique opportunity. But now, of course, there's been this explosion, but there's a number of, you know, all kinds of groups, associations. I mean, there's a lot of different opportunities for people to join communities. What I was wondering, can I get your take on that?

What kind of advice would you give parents, maybe especially our newer On this journey as far as how to navigate that without becoming overwhelmed? Because I think that's part of the— I think that's one of the challenges. Sometimes you feel overwhelmed already, just, I think, being on the journey. How, how—

Denise Allen [00:15:18–00:17:50]

How to navigate it? Um, you know, I think that we tend— I, I— what you said really hit— hits a nerve to that. You're right, we were very isolated. We were not just isolated, but marginalized. You know, we couldn't have a lot of the shared experiences that our peer group did.

Now, you know, Stone's a twin, and I also had another child, but when you wanna connect, not only do you not have the same experiences, the first day of kindergarten, as they, you know, they'll be waiting at the bus stop, all those little things, but you don't have the energy for it. You don't have the time for it. What I do love about the fact that it's, a lot of it social media driven now, is you can enter as you are able to enter. But what I think is the best way to not overload is to recognize that all of these people that are giving you their 2 cents worth are just people.

You know, they're not more qualified than you. They're certainly not more qualified than you about Your child. But I, I don't know. I mean, I, it's a good question and I wish I had a better answer for you right now because I am, um, I'm somebody who, you know, I'll, I'll research and, and learn and listen about almost anything. And I don't feel that I, that I necessarily overload because I can separate out, you know, the person from the idea they're presenting.

And I could connect with an individual even if I don't agree with them. I actually prefer engaging on social media because you can opt out when you overload. There's— you're under no obligation to respond to any message. That's a great point. You know, you can't necessarily walk away from an individual human being in the same room, but you can just turn off social media.

You don't even have to log in on a given day. Imagine that. You certainly don't have to answer all the things that are said to you. But there is, there are real relationships formed there and there is real value because there's nobody else out there who has the lived experience. You know, it's, it's a field that is overwhelmed by people who teach, not do.

And other parents are the people who may not be able to teach, but they sure know how to do. And if they don't know how to do, then whatever they've messed up is probably something you're going to mess up too, and vice versa.

David Kaufer [00:17:52–00:19:19]

Yeah. Yeah, no, that's a really good point. I think social media, again, I would— I was going to say, I think that's one of the benefits. Um, you know, again, we could say it's a double-edged sword. I, you know, I've worked in the industry.

I'm, you know, my day job, so to speak, is, you know, doing background PR and, you know, digital marketing. As I've been doing social media from the early days and I've seen the different changes, and again, it's become a double-edged sword, of course, with misinformation, disinformation, trolls, you

know, all kinds of things. The great thing is that, you know, some of these communities, like you said, the one that we're, you know, that connected us, the spellers community, and how that's just kind of—it's blown me away.

I mean, by far, but kind of the best online community that I've been part of. And like you said, just the knowledge sharing. I think for me, the difference is, especially again, going back 10 years and when we were kind of like in that knowledge-seeking phase especially, it's all There was like, there was an opportunity to ask a lot of questions. Like you could go to an association or a group and you, you know, you'd like read papers or you just like, and you're trying to make it kind of fit your situation, right? Like we know that everything is so unique that it's just really hard.

Plus it's just time consuming. Whereas again, like you said, here you go into a group and just say, here's my situation, you know, blah, blah, blah. What do you guys think? You know, and you get kind of that, that instant. feedback from people, um, in addition to the support, right?

Denise Allen [00:19:19–00:20:35]

Well, and it's okay to prioritize the things that you already like, what you're hearing. It's okay to do that. You know, when we were starting out, I went to Autism Speaks. It was the only thing out there. And I remember, I remember at the time, like, I was very, I was very grateful for the, the stability that they offered as an organization and we have the answers kind of thing.

Um, but anytime their advice didn't particularly resonate with me, I, what other choice did I have? I mean, there was no place else to look. And that doesn't mean that you decision shop, but if what you're working on right now is, you know, a biomedical intervention, if what you're working on right now is letterboards, if it's, you know, any one of a thousand different things, it's okay to prioritize the things that are already Working for your family and your values and your priority. Um, I think that we do—much like we put value on the spoken word, we also put value on the written word.

Just because you see it on the internet doesn't make it true. You know what's that like meme going around? Like, you can't, you can't believe everything that you see on the internet, and it's a quote by Abraham Lincoln.

David Kaufer [00:20:35–00:20:36]

Yeah, I love that.

Denise Allen [00:20:37–00:20:45]

You know, it's like that, but that's what the world is too, right? Like, it's, it's not any different from what we're doing in, in our day-to-day lives.

David Kaufer [00:20:45–00:21:23]

And you've got to filter, you've got to filter, you got to prioritize. And like you said, question, you know, ask, ask great questions and, you know, and understand where, where and who's the information coming from, what makes them qualified. You know, like I said, you know, I think that's always helpful, you know, to try to have those identifiers. You know, if there's a post and when people are responding, hey, You know, I'm a physician and I could tell you XYZ versus I'm a dad and here's my experience, right? We felt you and I have kind of offline discussion about— sure, about that. There's nothing, and it's not even like nefarious intent necessarily, but still I think that context is, is really helpful.

Denise Allen [00:21:23–00:22:52]

Um, well, I'll tell you what they do all have in common though. And I say, I say this about teachers too. One thing when I'm working on an advocacy case that I can always say is true about teachers, uh, special education teachers in particular, is there's not a one of them that entered that field because they thought they were going to get rich doing it. There's not a one of them that entered that field for the big paycheck, the short hours, the easy work.

Um, I don't believe you encounter anyone that is in any of those autism support groups for any reason other than they just want to do the right thing by themselves, their child, their family member, their loved one. They just— that, that is the one thing they have in common. And I think the overwhelming

majority of them would go to war in order to pursue that outcome. Um, that is a baptism or a shared bondage by fire, you know. And, and somebody else's way may not be my way, but I can absolutely respect that you are working all day long every day to remove barriers for your child.

And your solution might look different from mine, but your guide comes from the same place. And so I honor that no matter who's offering the solution. And in spite of what, you know, I tell myself on the daily, I don't know everything. And I've come across a lot of nuggets, a lot of nuggets that I just never would have considered had I not left myself open to that.

David Kaufer [00:22:52–00:24:20]

Yeah, no, that's a great point, you know. And the other thing, kind of in terms of a segue here, talking about 10 years ago, Something that I certainly didn't have that I wish we had. You know, Stone's wrapping up his high school experience now, thankfully, after, you know, communicating, spelling, and again, being able to understand his capabilities that he can handle age-appropriate material. He's now in a private school.

Again, for those who are listening, don't know my story quite yet, but again, after being in public school, we had to take some steps, some legal steps to get there. But, you know, like I said, this gets back to just, again, feeling like you're so alone. I remember knowing that he needed more support back way back when he was in 3rd grade, right? And, and, you know, you get into this world of IEPs and, you know, the public school district, and it's just, again, talking about overwhelming for the common person. I wish I had an advocate.

I wish we had someone like you, Elizabeth. I'm so— and I've had a chance to meet a few others, particularly from our group, who all— it's like, this is, this is something that's needed. Because it's just, it's just like I said, so overwhelming. And it's just the odds are really kind of stacked against the parents, you know, when you're— you feel like you're going into a knife fight with, you know, a fork, maybe, you know, plastic fork at that.

Denise Allen [00:24:20–00:24:53]

I think one of the reasons that it is overwhelming is because parents are told that they should be able to navigate it on their own. And so when they can't, they think something's wrong. Um, but you would never have entered into your legal battle without an attorney. So did you think that you were capable of doing that without— or you would never have, you know, self-diagnosed or, or whatever the many things are. But we're told we should be able to do it. We're told that the system is fair. We're told all of these things that aren't actually true.

Plot/Intro [00:24:53–00:24:54]

Right.

Denise Allen [00:24:55–00:25:13]

I do think the system tries to be fair, but ultimately, you know, you are representing your child, your heart, a piece of yourself. And for them, it's their job. And, um, they may care very deeply about their job. I don't doubt that, but not as much as you care about your child.

David Kaufer [00:25:13–00:25:25]

And I'm, I'm going to push back just a little bit in terms of, again, my personal experience in that, uh, I think your talk And I think maybe you're talking about the, the educators themselves. Maybe this—

Denise Allen [00:25:25–00:25:26]

Yes, I am. Not the system. No.

David Kaufer [00:25:26–00:26:24]

I think the system— I don't think the system— you know, this has been my, one of my takeaways and huge disappointments, crushing disappointment. I've always been an advocate for public education.

Um, my brother just retired. He was a, he was a middle school and high school teacher for a number of years. You know, like, it's just It kind of runs like, you know, runs in the blood sort of a thing.

And again, so that, that hope and expectation that, yeah, okay, yeah, they're doing the best, you know, this is really the best, you know, was shattered after a couple years. Like I said, once we— when we

knew that he— that Stone needed more support, deserved more support, we even provided some examples of how he had excelled with, you know, with some outside Um, you know, some of the outside work that we were doing, you know, and just to have it shot down multiple times. And then you just, I just felt helpless, right? Like then we were like, okay, we're just stuck in the system. We're just stuck.

Denise Allen [00:26:24–00:26:38]

So I don't think we disagree. So when I say they want to be fair, I think that they have an internal narrative about what it is they're doing. The, the actual deliverable is not necessarily fair.

Plot/Intro [00:26:39–00:26:39]

Okay.

Denise Allen [00:26:39–00:27:19]

I, I understand what you're saying, and I definitely have come across toxic people. It is rarely ever a classroom teacher. Rarely. I mean, maybe some very outlying, you know, outlying margins of people. I've come across one or two that, that it was a classroom teacher. It's usually the system. And I think that the problem's bigger than education because, you know, these are entities that survive um, with limited means and infinite need. And part of the reason that they can get through the day-to-day is through the system of smoke and mirrors, you know, borrowing from Peter to pay Paul.

David Kaufer [00:27:19–00:27:20]

And that's great.

Denise Allen [00:27:20–00:27:57]

You know, the ones who, who fall through the cracks are the ones that are more expensive to educate and the ones that are more— that, that require them to step outside of their standardized practice. And, you know, as a society, we don't value public education. We like to talk about Teachers and how great they are, and we'll give you your five percent discount at Starbucks if you show me your teacher ID. But don't raise my taxes because that might go to schools. Don't raise taxes. Don't do that because that'll go to schools.

That's an issue, right? You know, they it's not going to get better until the whole world recognizes the value of kids like Stone and Evan.

David Kaufer [00:28:00–00:29:09]

I hope you're enjoying the lighter side of the spectrum. So far we're commercial-free, but if you're finding value here, one way to support the show is by considering me for a speaking engagement. I speak on unlocking potential, whether it's for individuals like my son or for entire organizations. I also offer fractional CMO services for businesses needing strategic marketing support without the full-time commitment, drawing on over 35 years of experience in marketing. My agency has helped companies and healthcare practices increase their value, grow, and even prepare for acquisition.

To learn more about my speaking topics, visit davidcoffer.com, or if you're interested in our marketing or fractional CMO services, check out coffermarketing.com. If you're enjoying this episode, please leave a review. Your feedback means a lot and it helps me make this podcast even more useful. Lastly, don't forget to share it with anyone who would appreciate the insights and stories we're sharing Well, speaking of Stone, he's making an appearance. So he likes to pop in and just say hi and just let me know.

Denise Allen [00:29:09–00:29:11]

Yeah, I almost—

David Kaufer [00:29:12–00:29:12]

He's the best.

Denise Allen [00:29:12–00:29:21]

I got online, I, I thought to myself, you know, Evan, sometimes in the afternoon he kind of vocalizes, he gets a little loud. And then I thought, you know what, I roll all the audience in. That are still there.

David Kaufer [00:29:22–00:29:51]

Hey, right? Like, that's— this is our world. I mean, this is— especially again for you and I working from home and, you know, juggling that. But talk about, you know, again, we haven't really talked about— talk about like, what does it mean to be an advocate versus like, again, some of these people who are facing challenges, when might they look at talking to someone like you? Maybe not versus talking to an attorney, or in addition to Kind of help provide context for people to say, you know, what, what do you do?

Denise Allen [00:29:51–00:31:34]

So there's 2 things that I think are the most important skills that I have. Um, one is diplomacy, and that diplomacy probably rises to the level of either Henry Kissinger or Madeleine Albright, depending on your party. But, you know, pretty, uh, a pretty extensive, um, ability to manage those conversations.

The other thing that I'm very good at, I think, is translating school-ese to parent-ese and back again.

And those 2 languages are tricky 'cause they both sound like English, you know?

And I think about the movie The Princess Bride and where one of the characters says, you keep using that word. That does not mean what you think it means. About, what's the word? Inconceivable is the word that, and you keep using that word. It does not mean what you think it means.

And, you know, I can understand English and all the words separately, but not put together in that order. And that's— that is the source of a lot of the issues at the IEP table. So I guess I would say that the time to engage an advocate is when you feel that the tide is rising beyond your capacity to understand. And I know that that can happen very early, and not everybody has the means to do it. I, um, you know, I come to this work It's a second career for me.

It's the one I should have had all along, and I love it. I'm driven by it every day. People think I'm crazy, but hey, you know, somebody, somebody has to love it, right? That happens to be me. Um, I think that, um, because I come to this as a parent, you know, I give a lot of information away for free.

A lot of it for free. Yes, you do.

David Kaufer [00:31:34–00:31:36]

I'll vouch for that.

Denise Allen [00:31:36–00:31:39]

I'm happy to do that because partly because it's the person I want to be.

David Kaufer [00:31:40–00:31:40]

Yeah.

Denise Allen [00:31:40–00:32:32]

But also because I, I know I, I approach, I've been independently employed for my whole adult life, really 30+ years in another field before this. And, you know, I have always held by the standard that yes, information is power, but that power is magnified when that information is freely shared. I don't lessen my value by giving you what I know. What I do is I, I increase my value because I have Position myself as the expert and the source.

That doesn't mean I give away all my tricks of the trade, but I don't want parents to feel, you know, inhibited by, oh, I have to pay her for every 5 minutes of information that she gives me. Quite the opposite. You know, I learned a lot of what I know from parents who were willing to share a few minutes and answer some questions for me. And I just don't want to look back on my life and say I didn't do that for others.

David Kaufer [00:32:32–00:32:56]

What's been— I'm kind of curious, as you talk about that, what's been like one of the biggest surprises in terms of as you've kind of thrown yourself into this level of work for you? Like, have there been any like aha moments that have surprised you about being an advocate or what family, you know, families are going through?

Denise Allen [00:32:56–00:33:01]

My favorite, well, That part with families going through, no, because that's how I came through.

David Kaufer [00:33:01–00:33:03]

Because you lived it, right? Yeah.

Denise Allen [00:33:03–00:34:17]

Yeah. When I, when my son, my older son had a, got an IEP when he was 4, not for autism, but he had an IEP. And I remember at the time thinking, you know, I have, I have legal training. I have, I was a stay-at-home mom. I had resources in every way you could define those resources.

And I struggled. And I remember at the time thinking, if I'm struggling, what's happening to the other kids who are bringing less to the table than I am? And the answer is they're getting lost. Um, so what the parent experiences is not a surprise for me, and I think it's what part of what makes me good at what I do is because I know what it's like to be sitting at that table parsing out every deficit your child has. I hate that word deficit, but parsing out every bit of it and just feeling like, ugh.

Um, I think what has surprised me is the, the ability of people to the, to deny the obvious, to just be able to completely disregard the pink elephant in the room and just be able to— and I believe they really, they, they're not faking it. They really have built up this cognitive dissonance around, no, that's just not true. That's just not true. That's just not—

David Kaufer [00:34:17–00:34:21]

It's not true. It's not possible. Right? Like, right.

Denise Allen [00:34:22–00:35:22]

And, and how, how in some of these cases, People can look in the mirror and tell themselves that they're actually doing right by a child with a disability. I mean, think about that for a minute. You know, you're choosing to be right, your interpretation of right. Okay, so I'm not actually saying that there's a black and white, you're on, you know, the good guy, you're the bad guy. I'm not saying that at all. But what you think is right is, is happening at the Expense of a child with a disability. Meanwhile, you're presumably able-bodied in a position of power, and you know, you can choose between being right or being happy, and you choose to be right at the expense of this person that you are charged with their care and their education. I, I don't know how people build that high of a barrier in their mind. That's what you see.

David Kaufer [00:35:22–00:36:03]

I don't know either. I don't— yeah, it's hard. It's, it's impossible to understand, right? Because again, it's like, never been there, and again, I can't imagine going there. But like you said, it just, um, it just has never really made sense other than I guess you just— I don't know, you just have to convince yourself somehow that, that you're doing the right thing.

And this, you know, This is especially true, you know, in terms of that, just that bewilderment that I've had. And again, with the system, like, so there's one thing, like you said, to know that Stone was going through the school system before he could communicate. And like, and like you, Elizabeth, we— I knew that he was in there.

Denise Allen [00:36:03–00:36:04]

Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:36:04–00:37:08]

I knew that, right? And like you, it was just like, I gotta, I gotta unlock that key. You know, I just gotta find that key, whatever that is. You know, we're gonna find that and we're gonna get him out. But in the meantime, it's like, I still you know, wanted him to get an education.

And then as he got shoehorned into this kind of intensive ed, you know, the work experience program, you know, it was just heartbreaking to see that. But again, it felt kind of powerless. And then, you know, but then once he again attained the communication and we just said, hey, you know, we just want him to get access to education that we— that he deserves. And to have that just like turned down and just, you know, just like, no, he's not capable. I'm just like, why are you in this job?

Like, what, what, what are you talking about? And just that they were just so close-minded to even the possibility that he had the capability, even though, again, we, you know, we went through all the different assessments and things like that. Um, what do you mean? Just blew me away.

Denise Allen [00:37:08–00:37:49]

Yeah. You've heard me say online, and I wish, I wish I could just put it in people's minds before they go too far down rabbit holes. Minds don't change with evidence. They just don't. Because once you've made up your mind, evidence isn't going to be the thing that changes it. It's not how human beings are wired. Minds change with emotion. Um, I will also say I wish I had known that myself a long time ago because I was given so much bad advice in the beginning. So much bad advice. I mean, I look back now and the advice, the best advice available was bad advice, but I had—

David Kaufer [00:37:49–00:37:50]

That's bad. And that's bad.

Denise Allen [00:37:50–00:39:01]

Yeah. I had a Yale-educated pediatrician tell me when I informed her that we had received an autism diagnosis, she said to me, Well, you know, just because he's autistic now doesn't mean he always will be. That was one, that was one of the single worst pieces of advice I ever got. And the best advice I would, I could have received would have been, well, you know, he's the same kid before you had that word that he is today. He didn't change.

You just have a name for it. That would've been good advice. Now people say that. Now they didn't say that back then. And, um, Um, I still resent that.

Now, you know, through the eyes of a trained advocate now, what I, what I know what she meant was as young as he was, potentially, you know, developmental milestones are very highly variable. You know, it didn't mean that he was always going to present the way that he presented that day. But to say it the way she did and to imply that that was the gold standard, that he be non-autistic. was so offensive and so wrong and just not what I needed or any parent needs to hear.

David Kaufer [00:39:01–00:39:08]

No, no, that's so true. And like you said, yeah, I mean, you bring back memories.

Denise Allen [00:39:08–00:39:12]

Yeah, I do, don't I? We're getting a little twitchy because we're triggered.

David Kaufer [00:39:12–00:39:27]

Triggers. Yeah, I mean, part of this, you know, is, uh, it's survival, right? Like, you're— yeah, I didn't have You know, over the last, you know, what now, since the diagnosis, how much of this time have you felt like you were in survival mode?

Denise Allen [00:39:27–00:40:18]

I'll let you know when it ends. Yeah, because, because the threat is constant. The threat is— first it was — I mean, now I know I'm biased, okay? But he, my son, was a very cute little kid, very cute little kid. And the world would forgive him of a host.

of, of, you know, challenges that he presented. But, you know, now he's a hairy adult male and they're not as forgiving. And, you know, when I think of students that are students of color, that, that on top of them presenting differently and the risks the world presents to them, we live in a very judgmental world. It's becoming, you know, more so in the last 6 to 8 years as we've had people give voice to divisive language that validates discrimination.

Plot/Intro [00:40:18–00:40:19]

Yeah.

Denise Allen [00:40:19–00:41:02]

That validates the ugly things people feel inside. And, you know, it's, it's all very fear-based and lowest common denominator of our, of our experience as human beings. But I live that every day. And, and, you know, the, the stress hormone that, that, uh, what is the stress hormone? The, um, cortisol in your mind, in your brain. I'm absolutely sure that my, my cortisol level, my baseline is other people's stress level. 'Cause that's just what we live. And it, it, it's because I'm here to be protective of him and the world is a constant threat to him. Yeah. I think it's, it's survival.

David Kaufer [00:41:02–00:42:23]

That's just the reality. Yeah. And I think again, that's been kind of You know, I'm talking about what, you know, presenting and a lot of the show, you know, talking about the lighter side of autism, right? But that, you know, it's not all light, right? There is, there are some dark days.

There are challenges that, that we face, that they face, that I think, you know, we have to acknowledge. And I think, like you said, it's, it's kind of interesting how it— I don't know, for me, it feels like sometimes they just kind of come in waves too, right? Like you said, there was the just the incredible joy and, and excitement that came with spelling and the communication and all that that's opened up, which has been incredible. But then, like, you know, kind of once you get past that, the, the storming, the forming, right?

But then all of a sudden it's kind of like this reality of like, oh shit, like I've got this like incredible 18-year-old guy here who, you know, deserves an education. Like all this stuff has all these capabilities, all these needs. You know, now what? Like, again, there's still no, there's no roadmap for that. Like, there's no guide.

Like, we're, here we go. We, we got to figure out how to do this, how to get the degree, how to get into college. And I know there are others who have done it, but it's just kind of like this other, it's like, oh, here's another, another mountain in front of us now, now that we kind of got through that valley.

Denise Allen [00:42:23–00:42:47]

I think, I think once I got past the many lies the world was telling me about autism, it gave me permission to question more assumptions. And what that meant for us was education doesn't have to look the way that the public school system says it has to look. He doesn't have to finish at a, at a time—

David Kaufer [00:42:47–00:42:49]

That's a great point.

Denise Allen [00:42:49–00:43:26]

Yeah, it doesn't have to finish at a time that the public education system says most kids are going to be done. Um, we can write our own ticket. And, you know, I, I would not wish for, I don't think any parent would wish for their child to enter into a world that isn't built for them and that would constantly challenge that. But I am so grateful, so, so eternally grateful every hour of every day of my life, um, for, you know, the opportunity to, to refine life skills that he has needed me to refine.

Plot/Intro [00:43:27–00:43:27]

Yeah.

Denise Allen [00:43:27–00:44:00]

And it's, you know, it's not about me. It's not autism is my story, but parenting somebody and loving somebody the way that I love my child and knowing that the world isn't built for him, that is my story. And, um, I'm just so grateful. I'm a better person for what he needed from me. And I pity the people that don't witness the gifts that I get to witness and, and that you get to witness. What a gift it is to get a peek into these beautiful minds, you know?

David Kaufer [00:44:01–00:44:18]

Oh, that's a whole— that's a whole— that's a whole— that's a whole nother conversation we could have later, right? Because it, it truly is. And it's— yeah, it's a gift. It's fascinating. It's, like I said, exciting. It's, you know, there's so many words to use. It is a gift, though.

Denise Allen [00:44:19–00:44:21]

And somebody said to me Good.

David Kaufer [00:44:21–00:45:08]

I just want to back up on something you said because I think it's a really important point for people, especially if you're, again, early on with their journey. If you have, you know, someone, yeah, first, second, third grade or whatever it may be, like you said, don't be afraid to write the rules. I mean, again, I think we get— especially again, in my case, again, you feel like you have to be on this track and there are so many more options. You know, part of it, there are more options now. But again, open your mind to these options, whatever, you know, whatever it would be.

That doesn't mean go chasing down Fool's gold or whatever. But when especially it comes to education, really try to explore. Like you said, it could be— the path can be very different. It could look however you want. And that's, that's something I wish we would have done or could have done at an earlier age for students.

Denise Allen [00:45:08–00:46:04]

Yeah, people, people say to me in my practice things like, well, you know, what's he supposed to know by 3rd grade? And I always say, well, you know, grade levels are just stories made up by people sitting in a room in the state capitol, right? You know that, right? Like, there has to be standardization, of course, and there has to be some data by which we can measure things. But, you know, human beings aren't easily measured in 2-dimensional terms.

And so, you know, I always say let go of what the academic benchmarks are supposed to be, because that's an illusion, right? But do not let go of The, the demand that your, your child still deserves to love learning. And, you know, I, you can, you can miss a day, a week, a month, a year of school. You will catch up if you love it, but you will never come back if your spirit is broken around—

David Kaufer [00:46:04–00:46:05]

Right.

Denise Allen [00:46:05–00:46:29]

The idea of learning, being a lifelong learner. You know, it does. Learning didn't begin when you started school. It didn't end when you left school. Who among us are in the career that they studied for? You know, um, our local, uh, superintendent of schools here says something like 75% of kids in high school today will have jobs that don't exist yet. And, you know, so really what we're teaching them is how to think.

David Kaufer [00:46:29–00:46:30]

Yeah.

Denise Allen [00:46:30–00:46:46]

I have never used geometry after high school. I have never used— I mean, maybe I've used some algebra, um, but my point is I never, I never stopped loving the process of learning. That's what I want to protect in all the kids I work with, least of all my own, you know.

David Kaufer [00:46:46–00:47:30]

Protect. Yeah. And given the opportunity in some cases, right? Like I said, we know that, you know, there's some, some bad situations where they're not learning anything. They really are just kind of segregated into these kind of special ed classrooms where there's very little instruction and it's more You know, caretaking almost rather than— yeah, and then educational focused.

Um, it's funny you mentioned geometry, Elizabeth, and so actually that's one of the classes Stone's taking. And just, I think it was last week or so, you know, the teacher said, hey Stone, do you have any questions? And he said yes. And she's like, yeah, what's that? He said, how, how am I going to use this in life?

Right? The age-old question.

Denise Allen [00:47:30–00:47:35]

I can just I can answer that. Assembling IKEA furniture.

David Kaufer [00:47:35–00:47:36]

Oh, there you go.

Denise Allen [00:47:36–00:48:20]

But other than that, no. And if he's never gonna assemble IKEA furniture, and every college student has to assemble IKEA furniture sooner or later, um, you know, I, I have heard that, um, part of why a lot of autistic students love math so much is because there's rules and there's, it's clearly stated to them, this is what you do, this is how you do it kind of thing. I suppose there's organic pieces of geometry that unbeknownst to myself, I have, I have used in my life. Um, but Evan, man, he just can't get enough of math.

In spite of that, I'm quite sure he is actually my child, but he did not come by his love of math genetically. I can, I can swear by that.

David Kaufer [00:48:20–00:48:21]

Uh, yeah.

Denise Allen [00:48:21–00:48:35]

But he loves it. Good for him. Yeah. We all need something to love, right? Like, I'm happy it makes him happy, but. Me personally, I don't see the use. Who knows though? Maybe he's gonna launch a rocket in his life one day. Maybe he's gonna— who knows?

David Kaufer [00:48:35–00:48:46]

Who knows? I mean, again, right? I mean, it's not so far-fetched to say— again, I'll only speak for myself— that, you know, again, I didn't— I didn't think this day was going to be possible.

Plot/Intro [00:48:46–00:48:47]

I did—

David Kaufer [00:48:47–00:49:17]

Yeah, I didn't think that there would be the time that Stone would be where he is, you know, communicating, taking classes with, you know, so much potential, uh, opportunity, real opportunity in front of him. You know, this has just been it. So that has really inspired me again, just kind of in life in general. It's good to have a good reminder, like, we just, we don't know what's possible. I mean, it's a cliché, but it's so true. So who knows? Like you said, what kind of conversation are we gonna be having in 5 years about Evan?

Denise Allen [00:49:17–00:50:06]

Yeah. You know, like, I mean, my goal really is just that he's satisfied with the choices. I mean, I, I was raised by parents. More my mom, but my parents who used to say to me, look, if you decide that you want to sweep floors for a living, I will buy you the best broom and I will send you to the best floor sweeping school that there is. I just don't want you to be left with that as the only choice you have because of arbitrary barriers in your world. And that's what I want for him.

I mean, there's, you know, even if he's got, you know, all of the education available. He still has other very practical realities about navigating his world. I just see my role as, as a, you know, presumed neurotypical or, you know, neuro dominant. I like to call myself neuro fierce.

David Kaufer [00:50:06–00:50:08]

I like it.

Denise Allen [00:50:08–00:50:37]

Neuro fiercy. But, um, you know, I'll be the one to get the barriers out of the way for him, and then he gets to choose his path. And, you know, if he decides that just doing geometry exercises for the rest of his life, or Who knows? Um, I just don't want him to be left with that, that the only choice he has. I want it to be an active decision on his part. And so many people in the world, autistic or not, don't have that luxury. If I can give that to him, the luxury of choice, my work here is done.

David Kaufer [00:50:37–00:50:58]

So what, in kind of, uh, in closing, like I said, as, as we predicted, we could talk forever, you know. And like I said, I definitely want to have you on to another segment. There's a couple things didn't get to, um, that I think would be great topics. But in closing here, one of the things I was curious is what gives you excitement? What makes you excited about the future?

Denise Allen [00:50:58–00:52:18]

I think we just talked about it— opportunity. I look back at what it— we've talked about it actually a number of times just in this conversation. I look back at what the world looked like when I first entered. The experience that is parenting an autistic child. And that wasn't that long ago in the terms of human change. It was, you know, 15, 16 years ago for us.

What's it going to look like in another 15, 16 years? Because I look at the enormity of that change and it's, it's picking up speed. It's happening faster now. So if it were on a timeline and we've come, you

know, this far in that period, we're going to go much, much further than that in the next same time period. And I'm just grateful to sit back and bask in their reflected glory as they take on the world, you know.

Um, we're already seeing trends in workplaces where they actually seek out students who are employees that think like our kids do. That's just, you know, growing the seeds of change. Look at what the internet has done in the time we've witnessed it. So that's what excites And the world is waking up, maybe not as fast as I hoped for, but a lot faster than I thought would happen if I had to predict it.

David Kaufer [00:52:18–00:52:34]

It seems to be accelerating fairly quickly. And again, all right, you know, again, but maybe that's just a personal bias, again, based on my awareness. But it does, you know, again, it does feel like— it feels like this is really, you know, something that's getting some momentum, some real momentum, like you said.

Denise Allen [00:52:34–00:52:39]

I think it is. And I think that that's the way all change has occurred over history.

David Kaufer [00:52:39–00:52:40]

Good point.

Denise Allen [00:52:40–00:52:52]

You know, you— there's books written about it, about critical mass. And, and I, you know, that's what I think we're witnessing. You don't ever know at what point it happened till you're looking back on it, but it feels that way.

David Kaufer [00:52:52–00:53:30]

It does. It does. Yeah. I've been fortunate enough to, um, you know, in my career work in the tech industry and, and kind of pre, pre and early internet days. Um, you know, startups and like, and it's, it's really kind of funny that it has a similar vibe right now, kind of especially again in our, in our community of, you know, the non-speaking world, you know, and the, and, and the communicate, you know, the, the spellers, typers, you know, whatever you want to call them.

And this, this growth that we're seeing and this, this knowledge sharing, and it's just like, it's really, it really is exciting. That's, that's, that's what I'm jazzed about.

Denise Allen [00:53:30–00:53:38]

And I didn't work in the tech industry, but I was always an early adopter. You know, I was in the early days of Usenet and CompuLink.

David Kaufer [00:53:38–00:53:39]

Cool. That's early days. Yeah.

Denise Allen [00:53:39–00:54:11]

Was always an early adopter. And I, I witnessed what you're talking about, you know, not from the outside as a user. And so, yeah, I mean, I would liken where we are right now to when, you know, for example, AOL was huge and everybody was using AOL and eventually that outlived it. purpose. But at that point, you know, we, the animals had left the barnyard at that point. So, you know, I feel like we're in this, this phase where, you know, you tell 2 people and they tell 2 people and they tell 2 people.

David Kaufer [00:54:11–00:54:11]

Yes.

Denise Allen [00:54:11–00:54:23]

And sooner or later, you know, the, the community's gonna outgrow the box that it started in and it's gonna have to find a bigger box or no box at all. But yeah, it's, it's, I feel it too.

David Kaufer [00:54:23–00:54:53]

So maybe I'm as biased as you are, but Oh, we're kind of in the tornado, to use that, you know, that old, the old analogy. I remember there's something inside the tornado, right? That was another tech, the tech books. Well, gosh, Elizabeth, thank you so much. I mean, thank— first of all, thanks for being on the podcast. Also, thanks for all you do for the community, all, you know, the support and advice you've

given me. We're definitely going to have to pick this up and do, you know, a part 2, uh, down the road because there's so much, so much more to talk about. So thank you.

Denise Allen [00:54:53–00:55:39]

Well, thank you for having me and thank you for what you're doing to continue to, you know, be an advocate for this community with this podcast and in many other ways. You're a relative newcomer to it as opposed to me being the OG. But I just so appreciate people lending their own talents and gifts and connections and resources to expanding the message. You know, you talked about the reference to J.D. Henley and, you know, back when he was starting, I just happened to be one of the people he picked up the phone and talked to early on.

And, and, you know, every little bit, every person talking about it, you never know when that right person is going to hear something that's going to have some other gift to add to the community. So I'm grateful for you pushing that ball down the field a little bit further, too.

David Kaufer [00:55:40–00:56:12]

Well, thank you. And that's precisely my goal. Like I said, if it's one person who hears this, that again, that helps them and gets them on the path, you know, it's, it's worth it because we know, we know the tradeoffs. So, and if you are a listener, thanks for sticking with us through this. Hopefully you got a lot out of it. Feel free to give me feedback. My website is davidcoffer.com. Share this podcast with others who may find it interesting, and you can subscribe at all the usual suspects. So for now, we'll catch you next time on the lighter side of the spectrum.